DANIEL OVERBECK

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EMPLOYMENT

Assistant Professor of Economics (tenure-track) 2025 -
National University of Singapore (Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy)

EDUCATION

University of Mannheim - Economics, Ph.D. 2025

University of Bonn - Economics, M.Sc. 2019

University of Heidelberg - Economics, B.Sc. 2017

RESEARCH FIELDS

Public Economics, Development Economics, Applied Microeconomics

PUBLICATIONS

"The (fiscal) Dividend of Infrastructure: Roads and Revenues in Rwanda", with Abdou Musonera (U Rwanda) and Aimable Nsabimana (World Bank)
***Journal of Public Economics*, Volume 259, July 2026, 105676**

This paper shows that infrastructure investments enhance local tax outcomes. Drawing on a novel dataset combining information on the location and timing of all road upgrades in Rwanda with 12 years of administrative tax and census records, we estimate large and significant increases in tax revenues in municipalities near to upgraded roads. These effects are driven by firm entry as well as land value appreciation, captured through taxes on rental income at the local level. Finally, we show that while the additional revenues do not fully recover the central government's initial investment, local municipalities' revenues more than double within five years.

"Place-based policies, structural change and female labor: Evidence from India's Special Economic Zones", with Johannes Gallé (MCC Berlin), Nadine Riedel (U Münster) and Tobias Seidel (U Duisburg-Essen)
***Journal of Public Economics*, Volume 240, December 2024, 105259**

This paper quantifies the local economic impact of Special Economic Zones (SEZs) that were established in India between 2005-2013. Based on a novel data set that combines census data on the universe of Indian firms with georeferenced data on SEZs, we find that SEZs increased manufacturing and service employment with positive spillover effects up to 10km. This employment gain was paralleled by a decline in local agricultural employment, in particular of women, suggesting that the policy contributed to structural change. We find no evidence for heterogeneous effects between privately and publicly run SEZs or zones with different industry denominations.

WORKING PAPERS

"Bargaining Over Taxes", with Eliya Lungu (Zambia Revenue Authority)
CESifo Working Paper 12172

We show that bargaining over taxes constitutes a central feature of tax compliance in low state capacity environments. Using administrative records from Zambia, we document systematic deviations from predictions of standard models of tax compliance. Taxpayers bunch sharply in dominated regions above tax schedule discontinuities and at round-number payments. These patterns are inconsistent with standard models, but can be explained by bargaining between tax collectors and taxpayers, for which we provide additional evidence from our own taxpayer survey. Finally, we show that allowing for bargaining in standard models of tax compliance leads to Pareto-improvements if state capacity is sufficiently low.

"Carbon Taxation and Firm Behavior in Emerging Economies: Evidence from South Africa", with Johannes Gallé (MCC Berlin), Rodrigo Oliveira (UNU-WIDER), Nadine Riedel (U Münster) and Edson Severnini (Boston College)
NBER Working Paper 34406

This paper provides the first comprehensive evidence on how firms in emerging economies respond to carbon taxation. Using detailed administrative data, we study the announcement and implementation of South Africa's 2019 carbon tax—a potential trailblazer for other developing countries with limited state capacity amid the global expansion of carbon pricing. Contrary to concerns that carbon taxes might hinder growth or employment, we find no negative effects on firm performance or jobs. Firms facing higher effective tax rates increased activity following the tax's announcement, four years before implementation, likely reflecting the resolution of regulatory uncertainty and efforts to mitigate stranded asset costs. While we find no measurable reduction in emissions—likely due to this anticipatory behavior—our results suggest that carbon taxation can be implemented without harming economic outcomes, even in the short term and in low- and middle-income settings.

"Taxing FDI in a developing economy: the case of informality"

This paper introduces a new model which captures the effect of foreign direct investment (FDI) on a developing economy with an informal sector. The informal sector evolves endogenously as economic agents choose between working and setting up a firm and whether to do so formally or informally. FDI induces a uniform increase in labor costs but heterogenous productivity increases for domestic formal firms. Accordingly, some of these firms may opt for informality with increased FDI. This reduction in the domestic tax base may offset any revenue gains from additional FDI. It is shown that the revenue-neutral tax rate on FDI is decreasing in the government's efficiency in screening tax avoidance. Empirical evidence from panel data supports both key theoretical results.

WORK IN PROGRESS

"VAT Refund Delays and Firm Performance in Zambia", with Eliya Lungu (Zambia Revenue Authority) and Adu-Abaio Kwabena (UNU-WIDER)

MEDIA AND POLICY OUTREACH

"The Zambia Revenue Authority VAT panel", *WIDER Technical Note 1/2026, February 2026*

"How do small firms respond to turnover taxes?", *IGC Policy Brief, August 2025*

"How can informal interactions and bargaining affect tax compliance and enforcement?", *Tax for Growth, IGC Online Blog, December 2024*

"Place-based policy in India: How Special Economic Zones promoted structural change and women's employment", *VoxDev Column, December 2024*

"Place-based policy, Structural Change And Female Labor", *Faculti Interview, November 2023*

EXTERNAL GRANTS & SCHOLARSHIPS

£10,000 from International Growth Center, **P.I. and sole applicant** 2023/2024
(for survey + experiment in Zambia)

£2,000 from International Growth Center, **P.I. and sole applicant** 2024/2025
(for collaboration with the Rwanda Revenue Authority)

$10,000 from UNU-WIDER, **Co P.I.** 2023/2024
(for project: "Carbon Taxation in Emerging Economies")

Full scholarship for PhD coursework from German Research Foundation (DFG) 2019-2021

CONFERENCES & INVITED SEMINARS

2026 (incl. scheduled)
CESifo Area Conference on Public Economics (Munich), City University of New York (invited), Monash University Malaysia (invited), University of Mainz (invited), Goethe University Frankfurt (invited), University of Tübingen (invited)

2025
Paris School of Economics (invited), International Monetary Fund (invited, online), Wageningen University – Development Group (invited), National University of Singapore (invited), University of Stuttgart (invited), IGC Tax for Growth Webinar, CESifo Area Conference on Public Economics (Munich), ZEW Public Finance Conference (Mannheim), German Development Conference (Frankfurt), Taxing Smarter Conference (Lusaka)

2024
Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (Boston), National Tax Association Conference (Detroit), German Development Economics Conference (Hannover), ZEW Public Finance Conference (Mannheim), Annual Congress of the IIPF (Prague), Mannheim Taxation Conference (Mannheim), University of Mannheim, Walter Eucken Institut Freiburg (invited), University of Mainz (invited), University of Passau (invited)

2023
University of Zambia (invited), University of Mannheim, ifo Institute Munich, International Conference on Empirical Economics (Penn State University at Altoona), Annual Congress of the EEA (Barcelona), FHM+ Workshop (Frankfurt), South-Asia Institute/Heidelberg University (invited)

2022
CEPR/STEG Theme 1 workshop, Institute for Fiscal Studies (invited), Annual Congress of the IIPF (Linz), Annual Conference of the ETSG (Groningen), RGS Doctoral Conference (Bochum), University of Mannheim, EVS-online PhD Seminar, Mannheim-Frankfurt PhD Conference (Frankfurt)

2016-2021
12th Annual Conference on Economic Growth and Development (New Delhi), University of Mannheim

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Refereeing: Journal of Economic Behaviour and Organization, International Tax and Public Finance, Review of World Economics, Applied Economics, Palgrave books

Workshop/Seminar Organization: 7^{th} FHM Workshop in Development Economics (Mannheim, October 2024); Research Connect Seminar at NUS (2025 onwards)

Misc.: PhD Examiner; Master of Public Policy Admission Committee at NUS

TEACHING

NUS - Coding for Public Policy using R (MPP), Instructor	Spring 2026
NUS - Financial Management for Public Organizations (MPP), Instructor	Fall 2025
University of Mannheim - Public Finance (B.Sc.), TA and subst. instructor	Spring 2023, 2024
DHBW Karlsruhe - Philisophy of Science (B.A.), Instructor	2023-
University of Mannheim - Econometrics (B.Sc.), TA	Spring 2021, 2022
University of Bonn - Statistics (B.Sc.), TA	Winter 2018
University of Heidelberg - Mathematics for Economists (B.Sc.), TA	Winter 2014, 2015

RESEARCH ASSISTANCE

University of Bonn - RA for Moritz Schularick	2019
University of Heidelberg - RA for Axel Dreher	2015, 2016

NON-ACADEMIC PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development, Bonn, Germany - Internship	May-Jul 2017
Indo-German Chamber of Commerce, Pune, India - Internship	Oct 2016-Feb 2017

OTHER

Software: STATA, R, Matlab, Github
Languages: German (native), English (fluent), French (conversational, B1)
Personal: Married, two kids (born February 2019 and August 2024)

ACADEMIC REFERENCES

Prof. Eckhard Janeba
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